CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

ENROLLED AGENT (TAX PRO) IN THE AI ERA

Tax software files returns. An Enrolled Agent is who you call when the IRS writes back.

★ TL;DR — ~$75K median, and a federal credential you can earn in 6–12 months without a CPA degree. The catch: your year is ruled by tax season, and clients arrive stressed. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

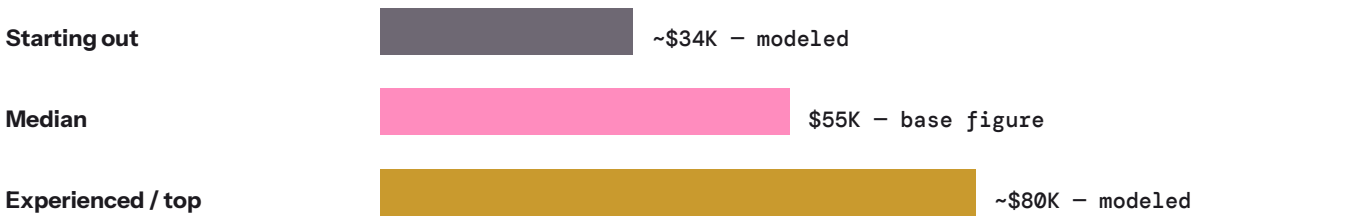
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$55K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

- The credential lets you represent taxpayers before the IRS — the same representation rights as a CPA, scoped to tax.
- Demand spikes every spring, and small firms and solo practices hire hard for it.
- AI prepares simple returns fine; disputes, notices, and messy situations stay human work.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Enrolled Agent (tax pro) is a ~$55K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A ENROLLED AGENT (TAX PRO) ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Prepare individual and small-business tax returns
- ✓ Answer IRS notices and represent clients in audits and collections

✓ Advise clients on deductions, entity choice, and estimated payments

✓ Keep up with yearly tax-law changes and filing deadlines

Think: a defense lawyer for tax problems — except the courtroom is paperwork and the opponent is a form letter.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Software and AI auto-fill returns, categorize documents, and draft standard replies to simple notices. Data entry — the old junior work — is mostly gone.	Judgment calls stay human: what position to take on a gray-area deduction, how to negotiate with a revenue officer, how to calm a client holding a scary letter.

⚠ **January to April is a grind — long weeks are the price of the credential. And a mistake on someone's return has your name on the line.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ A federal credential without four years of accounting school ✓ Clear path to your own practice — clients are portable ✓ Work compresses into season; summers can be light	✗ Tax-season hours are brutal and non-negotiable ✗ Clients bring you their worst paperwork and worst moods ✗ The tax code changes every year — studying never stops

Good fit? You like puzzles, paperwork, and being the calm expert in someone else's panic.
Bad fit? You hate deadlines that can't move, or you want a steady, even workload all year.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — TAX FIRM SEASON	DOOR B — CREDENTIAL FIRST
Start as a preparer at a tax firm or franchise for one season. You learn real returns fast, and the firm often supports you through the credential exams.	Study and pass the credential exams on your own schedule, then launch a small solo practice or join a firm already credentialed. Slower, but you start at a higher rung.

Smart move: Specialize early — IRS notices and representation work pay better than plain prep and are far harder to automate.
Where you land after: Senior tax pro, or owner of a small tax and representation practice.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN HOW	WORK ONE	MAP THE	PASS THE	GET ENROLLED	BUILD YOUR

STEP 1 — Learn how taxes actually work

FREE–$200 · MONTH 1

- Take a solid individual-tax course; prepare practice returns by hand and by software.
- Learn the vocabulary: credits, adjustments, notices, audits.

STEP 2 — Work one tax season

PAID · MONTHS 2–5

- Get hired as a seasonal preparer at a firm or franchise.
- Touch as many return types as they'll let you: gig work, rentals, small business.

STEP 3 — Map the credential

FREE · MONTH 5

- The credential is a three-part exam plus a background and suitability check.
- Build a study plan around the three parts: individuals, businesses, representation.

STEP 4 — Pass the exams

EXAM FEES · MONTHS 5–10

- Study part by part; schedule each exam as you finish its prep.
- Keep working prep or bookkeeping gigs between exams.

STEP 5 — Get enrolled and apply

ENROLLMENT FEE · MONTHS 10–11

- Complete the enrollment paperwork once all parts are passed.
- Apply to firms advertising representation and notice work, not just prep.

STEP 6 — Build your specialty

WORKING · MONTH 12

- Take on notice and audit cases with senior review.
- Decide your lane: firm career, or the first clients of your own practice.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: download the exam outline for the credential and price out a study course.
- □ Days 1–30: finish a fundamentals course and prepare your first practice returns.
- □ Days 31–60: apply for seasonal preparer roles before firms finish hiring for the season.
- □ Days 61–90: working or training in prep; exam study plan set with real dates.

□ Day 90: you're inside the pipeline — real returns under your belt and exam part one on the calendar.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **WHEN THE IRS WRITES, YOU ANSWER.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.